



RESEARCH METHODOLOGIES

Qualitative Fieldwork & Field Transcription Best Practices

Data collection protocols for verbatim transcription, audio privacy and ethical participant consent in SA

PDF PLAYBOOK · 1.8 MB · RESEARCH EDITION

Your Partner in Compliance, Research and Sustainable Impact

Qualitative Fieldwork & Field Transcription Best Practices

Good qualitative research lives or dies on the quality of its fieldwork and transcripts. Poorly captured audio, inconsistent notation, or shaky consent records can undermine months of work. This playbook covers the core protocols our research team applies on every engagement.

CORE FOCUS Verbatim transcription & ethical consent	APPLIES TO Interviews, FGDs & field observation	STANDARDS Aligned to SA research ethics norms
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1. Before You Go Into the Field

- Pilot-test your interview or FGD guide with a small sample first
- Prepare consent forms in the participant's preferred language
- Check recording equipment and bring backup power and storage

2. Audio Data Collection Protocols

The single biggest cause of unusable transcripts is preventable at the point of recording, not at the desk afterwards.

- Record in a quiet, low-echo space wherever fieldwork conditions allow
- Always run a secondary backup recording device where possible
- Label files immediately with participant ID, date and location — never rely on memory afterwards

Our full playbook includes a field-ready audio checklist and troubleshooting guide for common recording failures in outdoor or noisy environments.

3. Verbatim Transcription Standards

- Transcribe word-for-word, including false starts and filler words, unless your methodology specifies otherwise
- Use consistent timestamp notation every 60 seconds for longer interviews
- Flag inaudible sections clearly rather than guessing at content

Notation conventions for overlapping speech, code-switching between English and local languages, and anonymisation tagging are detailed in the complete playbook.

4. Data Privacy & Ethical Consent

- Store recordings and transcripts on encrypted or access-controlled drives
- Separate identifying information from transcript content wherever possible
- Retain signed consent documentation for the full life of the project

5. Quality Checks Before Analysis

- Spot-check at least 10% of each transcriptionist's output against the audio
- Confirm formatting is consistent before import into NVivo or similar software

Need transcripts you can trust?

SARE Projects Solutions provides transcription, translation, interview moderation, FGD note-taking and full research assistant support for academic, donor-funded and NGO research projects.

Share your project brief with us for a free turnaround-time estimate.

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This playbook reflects general best practice and should be adapted to your institution's specific ethics approval and methodology requirements.
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